

population and resources. It was theoretically a good strategy to concentrate South Vietnam's limited military strength on the defense of this region, but attempting such a withdrawal under the circumstances prevailing in spring 1975 invited disaster.

General Pham Van Phu, the commander in the Central Highlands, was ordered to move all his regular forces immediately from the major bases at Kontum and Pleiku to the coast at Tuy Hoa. The only road open to them was Provincial Route 7B, a jungle track requiring repair, bridge-laying, and mine-clearance to be passable. The withdrawal turned into a debacle. Discipline broke down as senior commanders abandoned their troops. Tens of thousands of fleeing civilians impeded the movement of military vehicles. The 320th NVA Division, pursuing the retreating South Vietnamese, threatened to cut the road entirely. NVA artillery bombarded the packed mass of troops and refugees as ARVN engineers worked valiantly to bridge rivers.

On 27 March, the disorganized remnants of the ARVN corps reached Tuy Hoa. About two-thirds of the original force of 60,000 men had been lost.



Chaotic retreat

The roads from the northern provinces were choked by a stream of military personnel and civilians fleeing south from Quang Tri and Hue ahead of the North Vietnamese advance.

Vital bases fall

Thieu's decision to concentrate his forces in more defensible positions precipitated a string of disastrous events in the northern provinces. The area commander, General Ngo Quang Truong, was told to hold the base at Da Nang at all costs, but his crack Airborne Division was withdrawn to strengthen the defense of Saigon. To replace the airborne troops, South Vietnamese Marines were pulled out of Quang Tri province to reinforce Da Nang. The withdrawal of the Marines triggered an exodus of civilian refugees southward from Quang Tri and the city fell to the NVA on March 19 without a fight. Deserted by civilians and military units, Hue was occupied by the NVA six days later. A flood of refugees and soldiers reduced Da Nang to chaos.